EXECUTIVE GUIDE TO CAREERS

Achieve your career goals and find stability, security, and order in your profession

16Personalities

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Introduction

Why Academic and Professional Development Matter to Executives

Executives tend to live up to their name, excelling as leaders, managers, and organizers. Whether they're coordinating group projects in school or supervising teams in the workplace, they lead by example, creating cultures that value hard work and dedication – principles that they uphold in most areas of their lives. Rather than grasping blindly toward the future, Executives learn from the past, identifying and sticking to best practices and proven protocols to ensure that they win the respect and trust of those around them.

Bold and detail-oriented, they make excellent administrators and decision makers in many different environments. As students, they're self-motivated, attentive, and remarkably efficient, capable of balancing a heavy course load with significant extracurricular obligations. Whether in the classroom or the workplace, Executives find it easy to assess and implement various action plans and to firmly defend their choices. Given their focus and dedication, they may make executing even the most complex projects look like a walk in the park.

Executives respect rules and guidelines, and their loyalty and sense of duty make them reliable, productive students and employees. They can be counted on to submit thorough, accurate work, never cutting corners or taking shortcuts. Not surprisingly, people with this personality type gravitate toward careers in institutions with strong traditions and explicit hierarchies, such as public service, law, and the military. Executives feel compelled to meet deadlines and deliver on assignments, so they may need to protect themselves from people who try to foist extra work or obligations on them.

People with this personality type may also find themselves at odds with their colleagues, teachers, or fellow students, particularly those who are sensitive to conflict or criticism. To reach their full potential, Executives may need to learn how to communicate diplomatically and acknowledge other viewpoints. They may also find that some of their career strengths, when unbalanced, could trigger their downfall. Executives who take an all-work-no-play approach may miss out on deeply rewarding opportunities for personal growth and self-expression.

In these pages, we'll discuss how Executives can maximize their strengths in their academic and professional careers while working through the challenges that tend to arise for people with this personality type.

Curious about the traits that make up your personality type and the theory behind them? You can learn more here.

Academic Path

Executives learn best in environments that apply the following three principles: structure, efficiency, and pragmatism. They thrive when these three principles are combined in the classroom – but are likely to struggle if even one is absent. By identifying their strengths and weaknesses, they can become very effective learners.

How Executives Learn

Structure

Students with this personality type prefer instructors who clearly define themselves as the leaders of their classrooms. Executive students trust their teachers are there because they have proper certification, training, and experience. In turn, they dislike classes being handed over to the students, such as those heavy on group discussion and opinion.

Executives' ideal instructors set goals and clear objectives, but if they feel it's necessary, these types set their own. Even if the tasks assigned are routine and repetitive, they don't mind if there are clear reasons for them. They thrive on timelines and benchmarks they can achieve through dedicated studying.

Efficiency

Unlike other personality types, studying is something Executives do very well. They utilize traditional learning methods like rote memorization and flashcards and are likely to dedicate time outside the classroom to mastering the topic at hand. Their ability to sit down, study, focus, and then execute what they've learned is unmatched by most other types.

This laser-like focus is attributable to this personality type's no-nonsense attitude about work. Executives strive for excellent results – while fun-loving and sociable, they take their studies seriously. Perhaps the quickest way to irritate these students is to goof off or slack off when there are important tasks to be completed. They demand competence from themselves and aren't afraid to demand it from others.

Because Executives are so focused on their work, they're likely to leave emotions at the door. This doesn't mean they're unaware of others' emotions – they're likely to pick up on peers feeling sad or angry – but caring about them is more of a delayed reaction. How they and others feel comes second to accomplishing goals, and Executives are honest and don't sugarcoat this. When criticized in turn, they don't view it as a personal attack. If anything, they'd be more uncomfortable with doing something wrong and no one correcting them to "spare" their feelings.

Pragmatism

In academics, their overall goal is to one day occupy stable, prominent roles in society. Often, this means a traditionally revered career – doctor, congressperson, and editor-in-chief – or as leaders in broader fields such as mathematics, communications, and the physical sciences. They also understand that opportunities are more readily available to students who graduate from well-established universities. This drive to one day be traditionally successful is the source of their strict study habits and focus while they're young.

Executives scan for how things "should" be, and are adept at spotting inconsistencies and failings. They're likely to find conflicting topics like art, philosophy, and other liberal arts subjects to be less appealing – these types don't relish debate for its sake in the same way as Analysts. If they do find this material interesting, they're still reluctant to pursue it, given their pragmatic focus (the exception is history, for its usefulness in understanding its modern-day context.) Regardless of their opinions on these subjects, however, they tolerate them to honor academic requirements. In any environment, Executives always work to deliver reliable results. They strive to be diligent students, no matter how uncomfortable they may feel.

Balanced Learning Habits

Fulfillment in the Community

Executive students learn so they can be contributing members of society. These exacting types take pride in supporting the established order and do what's necessary to keep things stable. They build on the foundation society deems successful, try to fit into their culture, and help mend things where they can. They learn what is necessary to fill an existing gap or follow a path that society considers not just acceptable, but prominent.

However, they understand that while it's important to meet societal standards and expectations, it's equally important to fulfill their personal needs. This can manifest in adults who are active community leaders, but also take time for an hour-long, once-a-week cooking class to learn how to properly braise a turkey.

Responsible Work Ethic

Executives subscribe to a rigorous work ethic and are known to keep working without breaks. They dislike the idea of not fulfilling their commitments and obligations (even if they didn't ask for them) and don't dismiss deadlines lightly. They complete all necessary tasks with diligence.

They also are likely to acknowledge the importance of good health to a balanced life. These students do what they can to turn in excellent work, but avoid pulling all-nighters and skipping meals. They evade such self-sacrificing methods by creating schedules that commit the effort needed to succeed, but also to eat and relax.

These students also aren't against letting loose occasionally. Executives take their duties very seriously but are happy going out with friends, even the night before a class, if the outing is reasonable. This is especially the case if the course is an elective they already have a good grade in. As the saying goes, "Everything in moderation, including moderation." Even if they allow fun to infiltrate work at times, they can rest easy knowing that the education system rewards students like them.

Allowing Innovation

Proud to be reliable, competent students, Executives achieve this by working within pre-existing structures and following traditional methods. This doesn't mean that they're completely against the unconventional – just that they take it with a grain of salt.

In the classroom, these types experiment (or allow experimentation to take place) with new methods if they show promising results, plausibility, and the likelihood of being better than their current ones. Despite their reluctance, they can find balance with the understanding that innovation sometimes leads to better things.

Unbalanced Learning Habits

Rigid Learning Style

Executives adhere strongly to well-established concepts and vetted learning methods. They may even go so far as to completely reject innovative methods, mostly to avoid the frustration they're likely to provide. Instead, they may rely on well-practiced techniques, with all the efficiency of experience, rather than something new and untested that shows promise.

This unbalanced approach can lead to a struggle with changing circumstances and expectations in teaching styles or subject material. Physical science courses may be a natural fit for these students: they establish base principles, then build on them procedurally in organized ways. However, if teachers cancel lab days, switch to "cooler" experiments at the last minute, or make other unexpected changes, Executives may struggle to keep up.

If they take it too far in this unbalanced manner – and decisive minds certainly can – these students may reject entire fields because of one bad experience with an inconstant instructor.

Learning for Status and Expectations

There are two broad types of motivational focus – internal and external. Internal motivational focus is based on what people want from life,

while the external type is based on what society tells them they *should* want. If students follow the latter to the exclusion of the former, their personal needs remain unfulfilled, leaving them educated but hollow. Executives who ignore classes they find interesting just because they don't fit their chosen majors can miss out on hobbies, friends, and even some resume-builders that show a range of interests – a surprisingly essential component of the interview process.

Expectations can emerge from internalizing a lifetime's external demands of meeting goals set for them by others, or from the real-time needs of family, community, and even school officials. They may lose their sense of independent decision-making, or even lose their characteristic decisiveness later in life. Adhering to expectations may work for some Executives if the demands aren't too exacting, but rigid and excessive expectations can lead to disappointment and perhaps the loss of a sense of individuality.

Both obligations and expectations give a sense of certainty, and there's rarely any doubt about how people should conduct their lives in their presence. But this assurance can come at a high price for Executives: a life lived more narrowly than needed, and experiences missed along the way.

Rebalancing Learning Habits

Learning for Personal Fulfillment

When weighing what they want against what society tells them they want, Executives may prioritize the latter. This unbalanced approach can lead to them feeling unfulfilled and, at times, resentful. To avoid this, these students can try these steps toward focusing more on meeting their internal needs.

- They can start by taking courses that are fun but "unnecessary" to their academic career. This should be doable, as these types aren't afraid of occasionally bold moves if they're sensible as well. They'll move cross-country – for a lucrative career. They'll buy a house – that's well-priced in an otherwise expensive neighborhood. They'll get married quickly – if they meet the person of their dreams). When changes make sense, they'll take the leap.

- When it comes to academic boldness, granting themselves happiness is sensible, too, as everything else hinges on it. They might learn about a subject they thought was interesting in elementary school, yet also ties into their general course requirements. Having an interest in the stars when young can translate to fulfilling a science requirement with an astronomy course, even if their major is accounting.
- By making small changes, Executives can gather the courage to take a particularly big leap – like going to a university they enjoy but isn't particularly prestigious. They can even reason that society's expectations demand self-determination and flexibility – and what better way to prepare than by using their interests to diversify academically?

Growing for Efficiency

Accepting innovation is what allows growth. From growth comes experience, which ultimately leads to efficiency. However, Executives tend to subscribe to the idea of, "If it's not broken, don't fix it." They may be unwilling to try new methods to shake the foundations of their academic career, whether they be alternative studying habits, allowing another student to take charge of a group project, or even changing their major.

To grow, to explore, and to continue learning, Executives need to become comfortable with the idea that "new" isn't synonymous with "inefficient." They shouldn't be afraid to test out whether that new high-tech calculator is as good as their old, faithful TI-83 rather than immediately writing it off. They could audit a new course and decide afterward if consequent courses in the discipline are a good fit for them.

It's the fear of failure or frustration that stops Executives from exploring. Remembering that failure speaks only for what's explicitly tried, not for all things new, reveals a way of thinking that more broadly applies the value of learning. Rejecting learning experiences because they're hard just isn't a balanced approach to knowledge. However, wise Executives also know that when they do fail, it can be an indication that it's time to move on.

Executives in High School

Even as teenagers, Executives are typically ideal students. They have an unmatched work ethic, are dedicated to turning in excellent assignments, and enjoy learning within the constructs of an established institution. While other students are off sulking or clowning around, these types flourish in the structured learning environment that is high school.

Executives tend to be "leaders of the pack" in high school – being mother hens in their social group, or taking control of team projects in class. As teens, they're more likely than their peers to know what they want from their academic career, and how to achieve it. Their assertive nature can be a powerful tool in the high school arena.

However, they can be intolerant of those who don't conform. Another area to work on is their strict adherence to the belief, "Working time is meant for work." Because of this, they may not fit into the more fun-loving high school scene and may avoid most teenage rebellion, an underappreciated phase of establishing independence.

In high school, Executives may benefit from their need to meet expectations. However, this benefit could also be their most significant challenge.

Balanced High School Learning Habits

The Path of Least Resistance

Efficiency is one of Executives' greatest strengths. They see a problem, gather information, decipher the clearest path to implementing the solution, and then do what they can to execute the plan. In high school, this could look like something small – studying for 30 minutes each day after school for a test that's two weeks away to achieve optimal results. On a larger scale, it could be deciding to be class valedictorian because it can make them more appealing to their dream university.

Executives, even in high school, actively avoid time-consuming obstacles, especially long arguments. While they're comfortable with confrontation, they're more comfortable with cooperation. They pick the path of being caring and patient with their classmates, even if it can

be just as easy for them to steamroll others. The reason these students do this can be summarized in the adage, "You can catch more flies with honey than vinegar."

Arguing over moot points or dealing with a classmate's hurt feelings, instead of focusing on the project at hand, isn't appealing to Executives. That's why they choose to walk the path of least resistance by considering the emotions and viewpoints of others, even if it appears more difficult at the moment.

Peeking Outside the Box

These students excel within systems that enforce structure and rules. This is why high school, in all its regimented glory, can be an excellent place for Executives. However, it takes a balanced approach to understand that life outside the walls of their school is far more complicated than third-period social studies ever let on. They know that for all their strengths, there are also weaknesses that have the potential to worsen after graduation.

To cover their bases, these masters of working "inside the box" can decide to peek past its confines and consider the option that other methods can be more effective. Executives aren't closed off to the idea that their way could be wrong, but what they do need is proof of it.

In high school, this manifests in these students taking a moment to consider the perspective from opposing classmates, or testing out new subjects rather than just assuming they won't like them.

Levity in the Classroom

Executives have a reputation for being killjoys, but that's not the case at all. They can be as fun-loving, silly, and bubbly as anyone else. Things become an issue when it comes to work and play – where others want to mix the two, Executives don't. Therefore, they can be easily irritated by classmates who goof off rather than focus on the task at hand, while classmates may think they're too buttoned up.

Executives with a balanced approach know that work and fun can coexist. While they're focused on getting the job done, they also understand that others don't have the same sort of tunnel vision when

it comes to work. Rather than following their inclination to say, "Forget it," and plow through all the work themselves, they instead figure out a way to communicate in a mutually beneficial way. This isn't to say that they let thing slide easily. They can allow a short amount of time for peers to joke and laugh, before gently reminding everyone that there's a task to complete.

Unbalanced High School Learning Habits

Doing Only What's Expected

Executives are dutiful and committed, driven to meet the expectations placed upon their shoulders. While this often works in their favor, it can also turn against them. They may be so focused on meeting requirements they miss out on doing things they enjoy.

Being good students involves meeting specific benchmarks, but it's also about finding joy in what is learned. Unfortunately, these types may find that they've lost that joy on the path of meeting others' expectations. Take, for example, those consumed with studying for a standardized test. Of course, they'll do well and earn stellar scores that qualify them for college. But they'll also wonder if any of the information learned has any personal value. This may be more the fault of the education system than the students, but Executives have an obligation to themselves to learn beyond what society tells them is important.

Since they run the risk of not discovering things they enjoy, they may never let themselves find their passion or specialize while they're still in high school. This, in turn, could lead to steeper challenges in higher education or the workplace. While there's nothing wrong with taking the well-tread path, Executives should take care to understand themselves.

Rigid Responsibility

One challenge that Executives face in high school is that they possess a certain rigidity. When it comes to work, these students leave their emotions at the door and expect others to do the same. They may see explanations from their peers as contemptuous excuses.

When they have an unbalanced, hard-nosed approach to school work, Executives may have trouble with their fellow students. Since upholding standards is a large part of their motivation, seeing other students disregard rules or even take breaks may upset them. There can be mutual frustration – these types can see their peers as lazy and unwilling to work hard, and peers can see Executives as uncompromising, perhaps even as bullies.

Even when they don't intend to push their peers around, that's how it appears when well-intentioned Executives try to force their work ethic and standards on others in an unbalanced manner.

Fighting for Control

Executives like to manage things, but what happens when they encounter those who don't want to be led? Students with the Executive personality type may opt to make others conform to the best of their ability – or cut them out entirely. This unbalanced approach can play out in many ways: harsh criticism, strict exclusion, or merely finding reasons to report out-of-sync students to their teachers.

These types can't see why others wouldn't want to go down the established path. They may even see it as an insult to their competency, reliability, public image, and sense of fair play. This unbalanced approach can lead to their taking offense that they should work so hard and others so little, while everyone manages to pass in the end. Executive students can be swift and harsh in venting their frustrations.

Rebalancing High School Learning Habits

Utilizing Patience

Because teenage Executives take their work seriously, they may feel frustrated with the ruffians and slackers in class. They may think to themselves, "Why can't you just do the work?" or "Is it so hard for you to sit quietly in class and listen?"

If troublemakers genuinely disrupt Executives' learning or the learning of others, they're more than capable of letting their irritation be known. Before acting, though, they should consider the perspective of

the disruptive students, or their outside situations, and then decide if there are issues to address. The disruptors' actions could be due to misunderstandings or miscommunication, or they might be acting out or missing deadlines because of complicated home lives. Always keeping patience in mind, Executives can try the following when dealing with problematic classmates.

- They can channel their pragmatic fairness when distributing the work, and holding others accountable with clear goals.
- They can also make group study a priority, which can help keep others on task by creating a sense of group purpose.
- Opportunities for mentoring, and the chance to offer a plan with mini-goals to keep everyone on track, can also help.

Mixing Work with Play

These students want to make sure there's a distinction between work and play. For Executives, the goal is often the only thing that matters during a project, and they find those who aren't willing to work toward the goal just as quickly or efficiently to be extremely aggravating.

To balance this, Executives can factor some downtime into their studies and group work. Suggesting 15-minute breaks for every 45 minutes of work is a good start. Studies have found that most people have a hard time concentrating on their work after 30–45 minutes and that continuing past that time can lower productivity and work quality. This isn't just a matter of work ethic, but a valid limitation of the human brain.

Despite this fact, Executives are inclined to push past their limits, even taking on others' work. However, doing this isn't fair to young Executives, or to the other students who then miss out on opportunities to learn (or fail) for themselves. Setting up a group plan creates natural accountability measures, and can help Executive students maintain a lower-stress approach while still getting results.

Beyond Expectations

Young Executives operate well in areas where expectations are clear, and they work diligently to perform for those they care about – parents, mentors, teachers, friends. They place immense pressure on

themselves to succeed for themselves and others. However, there's a vast world of unique expression beyond the boundaries of these underlying cultural assumptions. Clinging tightly to expectations can be both limiting and exhausting. The high school years can start the journey of self-discovery that lasts a lifetime, and releasing the grip of expectations can strengthen the early stages of this discovery process.

Consistently impressive performance according to standards is a good thing. But to grow, students with this personality type also want to balance this by adding activities they enjoy. The high school environment allows them to begin building a sense of who they are, and to find personal passions. Below are some questions to find out what those passions may be:

- As a child, I thought of becoming_____.
- Most people don't know this about me, but I enjoy _____.
- I am the go-to person when my friends need help with _____.

Once there's some sense of what fills high school Executives with a sense of purpose and enthusiasm, they can begin to explore in practical ways. They might talk to a guidance counselor about what activities correspond with their interests. They can join clubs where there are enjoyable activities and like-minded individuals. Finding others in the community who might be willing to mentor them – a guitar teacher or ski instructor, for example – can give them access to a skill, but also someone more experienced in general.

In high school, even steadfast Executives are likely to change their minds and their professional aspirations. Interests aren't permanent, particularly in adolescence. These students can give themselves permission to be flexible as they decide directions and passions. Having a sharper image of who they are as people, both through self-awareness and experience, they can start to determine what meets their goals: the workforce, or higher education.

Work or College?

Go to college, or go into the workforce? This fork-in-the-road decision plagues all young adults as they prepare to leave the swaddling comfort of high school. While personality type isn't the only factor that goes into making this choice, it can be an important variable. The question many Executives have is whether it's more practical to enter a trade early to begin establishing their lives, or to bolster their future security by obtaining a degree.

Core to their consideration is cultural expectations, especially regarding what they perceive as societal success. They can find themselves hard pressed to defy a family full of college graduates. If the choice is available, they're more likely to pick prestigious (but perhaps expensive) universities over more economical community colleges or trade schools – unless those options are themselves part of family or community pride.

Either way, it's important for Executives to know that they have choices available to them. So, what are some things they may consider when making this decision?

Balanced Decision-Making

Understanding the Path

By the time their high school graduation rolls around, many teenage Executives decide on what careers they want to pursue. If positions that meet their career goals are immediately available – say, taking over the family restaurant – then they may jump in. Using the same example, they're also just as likely to balance taking over the family restaurant while taking business courses at the local university.

On the other hand, they're likely to go to universities that provide suitable learning environments for their ideal careers. If they decide to be, for example, a congressperson, they'll choose a school that's produced other reputable government officials.

Most importantly for Executives, a balanced decision is based on not only the school's societal standing but how they feel about it – not to mention the broader career path that pushes them there. Of course,

they want to attend well-respected universities, but they also want to feel they can fit in enough to participate in their campus communities.

Understanding why they want to do what they're doing can also provide a more definite sense of what the future holds. Executives regard risk with some caution, but a balanced approach helps them realize when they've spent enough time considering, and when it's time to take bold action.

Unbalanced Decision-Making

Risk of the Unknown

The idea of leaving what they know for an unknown future can be terrifying, so Executives ground themselves in the established – but an unbalanced approach can take this too far. They may assess a situation, but assume anything new at all is risky, and find it lacking any assurances.

Fear of the unknown can force Executives into early, entry-level work and keep them there, whatever ambitions they may harbor. They don't necessarily stay because they want to or because they like their work. Instead, the choice of the road less traveled may seem too stressful, and they opt for the comfort of the familiar.

A risky path has no outcome that guarantees where they'll end up, and they don't know if they'll waste their resources pursuing something that means nothing in the end. The risk Executives fear is that they won't succeed – or that, in their success, they won't be able to rise to new responsibilities. Home and work may appear to be safer harbors, and school as a mere hiding place from transitioning to the working world. They may choose safety, and consequently miss professional and personal opportunities.

Adhering to the Checklist

Risk and cost are both a part of growth. There's a difference between choosing prudently and choosing from limited options, and if a checklist becomes too rigid, the first can become the second. In their diligence, Executives may too quickly eliminate anything outside of overspecific

criteria. Because of this, they may miss opportunities that can otherwise benefit them.

It may be important to remember that college, especially when entered in young adulthood, offers more than a diploma. It's often students' first exposure to independence, and those who move away from home learn to take care of themselves on a new level. Ideally, different institutions and programs encourage college students to think for themselves to varying degrees.

Keeping this in mind, Executives on a college tour (which they'll no doubt take) should choose a university based on how well they fit into the environment, and not just on the prestige of the institution. Ultimately, it's better to have a positive college experience that shapes them for the rest of their lives than just an Ivy League name to fall back on.

Selecting for Others

Executives may choose to go to college because it's traditionally the path family members have taken, or what their community tells them is the best route. Even if they have in mind a career that doesn't need a college degree, they may not want to go against the grain. They can foolishly spend time, money, and enthusiasm because of this.

When these students defer this decision solely to others' opinions, they set themselves up for passive roles in their own lives. Executives who don't include their independent opinions in their work or college decisions may be disappointed in themselves later and wish they'd taken a stronger stand. Denying themselves this first significant opportunity for deciding their unique life directions sets up patterns that can be difficult to break.

Rebalancing Decision-Making

The Value of Risk

There's a certain degree of perfectionism among Executives, and they may have it in their minds that failure just isn't acceptable. Their fear of risking the unknown is often part of protecting their reputation for success. Taking a reasoned risk is different from choosing a reckless

one – it means taking action that could be rewarding enough to outweigh the chance of failure. Those who unshackle themselves from demanding perfection take risks necessary for greater rewards. Choosing their paths, despite the unknown, can lead to the reward of personal satisfaction.

Executives can take the following steps to unlink from perfection and excessive risk avoidance:

- **Make the unknown known.** While this is, of course, impossible to achieve one hundred percent, Executives can get a little closer by talking to people who have had different experiences with entering college and making choices about work or college. If real-time conversations aren't possible, there are over three million responses to the YouTube query, "Why I decided to go to college." For a more concrete look, examining job listing requirements in a desired line of work can provide a clear answer quickly.
- **Voice concerns.** Talk to a trusted someone who is likely to be objective. If still in high school, guidance or college counselors may be helpful. Older family members or family friends might be able to lend an ear and some of their experience. Those who listen may be able to offer solutions, examples from their personal decision making, or just provide an audience for venting.
- **Attitude check.** Examine personal attitudes about failure and what it means. Few failures leave a permanent mark – more often, they teach and show that people are moving forward and challenging themselves. By assuring themselves success – eliminating the risk of failure – Executives hold themselves back. This attitude is a choice, but by embracing future options, it doesn't have to be a permanent choice.

Allowing Checklists to Evolve

Executives' college checklist can be fraught with limitations, whether self-imposed or imposed by others. Expanding one's options is a creative act that reaches beyond assumptions and explores possibilities outside of the obvious. Executives are likely to protect their decisions and beliefs, and that's fine. But novel options might also fit into the list and expand it. Or, there may be completely different alternatives worth

exploring. Either way, Executives working to rebalance must make the decision that they owe it to themselves to explore all practical options, rather than assuming no others exist.

Executives can start exploring some options beyond the obvious by identifying a choice, and some beliefs about that choice. What makes this option viable? Why is it a choice to begin with? This list should be as detailed and comprehensive as possible.

With this analysis in place, they can ask themselves whether there are options worth exploring or beliefs that are useful that didn't make the cut. What would their opposite type – many of whom carry on very successful lives by any measure – come up with? It's possible that nothing practical may arise from this exercise, but it also carries minimal risk to try.

Finding Personal Value

One of Executives' best traits is that they're honest. If they honor this trait, it may temper the influence that outside forces have on their decision-making. Their internal motivations are likely to be more consistent over time, and being honest with themselves means finding answers within and aligning the best ones with society's standards. These students are more likely to find their unique directions if they consult themselves first, and it's the least they deserve after all their hard work.

When choosing a direction after high school, Executives can explore the following questions with one- or two-sentence responses, remaining as concise as possible.

- When do you feel most engaged and enthusiastic?
- When did you overcome a difficult challenge successfully?
- When have you felt you were "in the zone?"
    - What were you doing at the time?
    - What were the principles you followed?
    - What did you do to reach your goal?
    - Did you feel personally satisfied by your accomplishment?

- Bearing in mind the challenges you face now (and possibly in the future), how can you build on what you know works?

Answers to these questions are likely to demonstrate Executive students' interests and passions, providing a place to begin exploring the future. Those who commit to something they believe in are likely to see it produce results more effectively. It's a relatively short step from discovering their interests to developing an action plan that uses them well.

Executives in College

College autonomy may disorient Executives at first, as it does most young adults. Separated from their friends and family for probably the first time in their lives, they no longer have the structure on which they've come to depend. This new independence places them out of their element, but this is likely temporary as they search out new benchmarks to pursue.

Balanced Approach to College

Conscientious and Responsible

Considering they spend their young lives looking for guideposts to direct them, these types can find structure in university life in the form of clubs, study groups, or campus positions. If they can't find an organization that meets their needs, then they can take it upon themselves to create one – a young accounting major who's perturbed by the lack of community in her field can tap into her Executive traits and create an Accounting Society to bring accounting majors together.

Course choices in college are like the subjects these students chose in high school. They excel in any detail-oriented work that needs widespread delegation and follows established protocol, such as political science, business administration, engineering, and law. For them, subjects aren't nearly as important as their application and purpose. These types like the most direct path to their goals. Executive students aren't generally attracted to less traditional courses, so they're unlikely to be found in a women's studies course or a survey class of radical political movements. Their interests tend to lie in more bedrock courses – perhaps something their parents took a generation earlier.

These responsible students strive to set themselves up for success. Executives read, and even study, their course syllabi (unlike their peers) like religious manuals, and treat them as welcome frameworks to hang their college lives from. They avoid classes at eight in the morning if they know it's difficult for them to get up early. They turn in quality work exactly when it's due. In a sense, they trade in the rules of high school for an updated set of rules for college. Unlike many other types, they don't flounder in their new environment, but instead find the well-worn path that's worked for those who have gone before them, and begin their journey by following in their footsteps.

Gathering the Tools for a Good Life

Although some college students decide to party their four years away, this is far removed from healthy Executives' intentions. Their main reason for choosing higher education is simple – to receive the certification or degree required to advance them toward their chosen career and carry out their life plans.

College is an arena for personal experimentation for some, but these students see it more as a hardware store from which they can acquire the tools needed to build a stable, steady future. They utilize college resources to the best of their abilities – campus services, career fairs, their professors, and, of course, information geared toward making advantageous academic choices. For them, college is all about forming strong foundations.

These foundations also include those of the social variety. Executives are inclined to join social communities – Greek life, for example – because the prospect of making strategic connections with their peers is very appealing. They don't do it for friendship, necessarily, but because it's another tool to utilize for success.

Unbalanced Approach to College

Lost in the Halls of Education

In high school, grown-ups carefully directed students' activities, but the autonomy found in college presents a sudden radical shift from such micromanagement that can overwhelm young adults. It's

common for first-year students to succumb to feelings of depression and disorientation as they attempt to navigate the brave new world of higher education. It's reasonable to see why Executives may indeed feel like lost souls when pushed into this more unstructured environment.

In college, all work is in some sense independent work, and guideposts and supports are less available. For many of these students, it may be the first time no one's explicitly told them what to do. For those who are too dependent on external structures, the early years of college can be painful and disconcerting. Executives hate feeling ineffective, and a challenging start in college may be indistinguishable from that feeling. If they aren't careful, it might set the tone for the rest of their stay.

Overload and Drudgery

In their desire to set solid foundations while in college, it's natural for Executive students to overload themselves. Whether it's the pressures of the school's requirements or the expectations they pile on themselves, sooner or later, those who haven't learned the art of balancing self-care and responsible behavior become overwhelmed and stressed.

In high school, their capability to stress themselves out may have been lessened by smaller workloads and fewer expectations. In college, however, Executives have free rein to express their perfectionism within their chosen courses and activities. They can also add stress to their lives by pushing for too much detail and making excessive demands of themselves. Such demands include not cutting themselves slack when they make mistakes, overworking to achieve and maintain high grades, and pushing themselves to meet high social expectation.

As the weight becomes heavier and heavier, Executives continue to smile dutifully, even as they begin to falter under pressure. Despite their compliant smiles, this stress can erode not only their effectiveness but also their morale. They're likely to push through and succeed anyway, but success drenched in stress may not make the ordeal any less miserable for them. Instead of a rewarding experience, their college years can soon represent drudgery and regret.

Rebalancing Their Approach to College

Finding their Way

Executive students tend to seek out the structure they need and find examples of success to use as precedents to follow. Finding their way may come naturally, but a lot depends on their maturity level. Younger students may need more help than older students entering college. But the truth is, it may be difficult for these stoic types to ask for the help they need at any age.

If Executives find themselves stressed out by higher education's lack of structure, they may want to make alliances with other students, preferably more experienced scholars. Some colleges offer mentoring programs where older students take new ones under their wings. Joining campus organizations can also be a place to see how others navigate the autonomy.

Reshaping Unreasonable Expectations

Just as they may have had issues with taking breaks in high school, Executives in college may be unwilling to deal with the root of their stress – meeting unreasonable expectations, like maintaining a perfect grade point average while taking a full course load of rigorous classes *and* working a part-time job. Any objective assessment would call such a schedule an unrealistic burden.

The first step to dealing with massive expectations is to acknowledge they've created an unreasonable situation for themselves. One simple way to check is to ask, "Would I ask someone else to do all these things? Would I wish this schedule on my best friend?" While they may project their expectations onto others at first, their more rational side is likely to give an objective answer. (The correct answer is that such schedules can prove to be soul-sapping burdens which shouldn't be wished on anybody.) For Executive students, making realistic assessments is an important step in goal-setting.

These students suffer in silence because they believe they should be able to handle everything expected of them. They view meeting expectations, no matter how unreasonable, as a duty, so they grit their teeth and bear the pain. However, to be better-rounded individuals, it's

necessary to understand that it's okay *not* to be okay sometimes. Pain, discomfort, and emotional stress are early warning systems that alert people to change course or suffer further damage to their well-being. Executives help themselves when they learn to treat these warnings with respect and heed the information they provide.

Becoming literate in the language of one's feelings can be as simple as raising awareness. One method involves setting random alarms on phones or watches to go off at unexpected intervals. When the alarms sound, make a note somewhere with the answers to two questions:

- "What is my current feeling?" Discouraged? Tired? Hopeless?
- "What is the feeling telling me?" The feeling of discouragement can foreshadow an impossible afternoon filled with too many arduous tasks.

Many dutiful people learn to ignore their feelings. Bringing them back into the conversation can help Executives deal better with unreasonable expectations and consider their well-being more often.

Lifelong Learning

For Executives, "learning" is very much about gaining applicable real-world skills to create and maintain stable lives, including serving the people and organizations they respect in improved ways. These types tend to continue to learn if doing so supports the lives they hope to build.

Balanced Lifelong Learning

Reaching Outside the Comfort Zone

Mature Executives recognize that there's knowledge outside of the scope of their experience and education. To become better at what they do and who they are, they understand they may need to increase their knowledge from time to time. There may be occasional reluctance because learning means change, and that isn't always comfortable for them. However, with experience comes the understanding that growth takes place outside of one's comfort zone.

Having Time to Learn

As these types get older, obligations grow and time becomes a precious commodity, making it easy to become completely swept up in maintaining what they've built. Finding time to learn something – even if it offers a tremendous benefit – can become challenging. Making time to become "better" may seem like a luxury.

Executives who carve out time in their busy lives to pursue new information or skills can make themselves more effective, and perhaps their lives more enjoyable as well. While work and personal obligations are important, so is finding room to incorporate new skills into their everyday routines. Novice cooks may need to take some time out of their day to learn the skills to produce nutritious meals at home from scratch, but the health benefits and enjoyment factor can make it all worth it.

Learning New Skills to Complement Old Lives

Executives don't learn new things for the sake of novelty, but because they can apply them to practical aspects of their lives. They take the time to examine life and wonder how they can enrich it for both themselves and the people around them.

This preference for practical learning can manifest itself in pursuits like taking an automobile maintenance course so they can handle minor car issues on their own. Or, by picking up carpentry, they can create simple furniture pieces to pass on to their children. If they learn how to grow a vegetable patch, they can use their produce in healthy meals.

Enrichment learning may seem like "extra" to many busy Executives, but such pursuits add texture and dimension to lives, and, when balanced, without interfering with effectiveness. It's not about novelty or an attempt to tamp down boredom. It's about taking a good life and making it even better.

Unbalanced Lifelong Learning

No Time for Learning

Those who decide they're too busy to learn something new may be robbing themselves of personal and professional growth. In this

changing world, neglecting professional development can mean the loss of a promotion or even a job. (Losing a job would certainly solve the problem of being too busy.)

As far as personal growth, one of the issues that Executives often face is the vague sense that they're just cogs in a machine. Some lose their sense of individuality and, consequently, personal value. Learning the right things can help them distinguish themselves from others and give them a stronger sense of their uniqueness.

Settling and Stagnation

These types often choose contentment and reject change as a threat to it. When deciding on a direction in life, they may decide against something new as a way of leaving "well enough alone." Unless there's a very compelling reason to take a course or to pursue a new direction in learning, they may forego it to protect what they know. What others see as a type of stagnation, Executives see as a form of maintenance. They may not see the value of disrupting their routine by learning to grow a garden – there's always the supermarket, just where it's been for years. Shaking up their predictable lives with new information can be difficult and perhaps even threatening.

If their level of contentment is high enough, they might believe that there's nothing else of value for them to learn. They may question what they need to add to the lives they already respect and value. Consequently, they can miss out on so much.

Rebalancing Lifelong Learning

Finding Time to Learn

Time may be the most significant obstacle in Executives' academic development, with other obligations distracting them from learning. However, it's important for these types to carve out time and put themselves first on occasion. Creating space for self-care can help lower stress and improve their overall mood. Taking time to grow in stimulating ways can be a healthy part of a stress management program. They can begin by committing at least an hour a day to learn or practice a skill they enjoy, incorporating the hour into their routine.

- Those who like to relax and watch television for a couple of hours at night can also use that time to practice knitting or sewing. (It may take an additional hour or two to learn the technique.)
- College level courses are now streamed through many devices and can be entertaining – learning and relaxation available in one place.
- Crafty people teach artistic and artisan skills throughout YouTube. It's a miraculous age for pursuing lifelong education, and it's rare that an hour or so can't be found to enlarge a life. There are many ways for the willing individual to fit learning and growth into even the busiest day.
- There can also be a social aspect to learning, and the right classes might involve meeting new people and making it well worth finding an hour a week to learn. Single Executives may be especially interested in this aspect. Combining one's social life with learning (or vice versa) can deliver two wonderful things in one package.

Varying the Routine

Being "set in your ways" isn't necessarily a bad thing. However, there's always room for improving upon an existing routine. Executives can begin this by picking a relatively mundane task – take, for example, a walk. Rather than taking the same path every day, they can choose a different way every other week – a walk on a forest trail, a walk through the city, a different route through the neighborhood. Even a small variation can loosen up the tight grip an existing routine has on life and begin to open new vistas of learning.

Using their small excursions, Executives can then adjust their routines based on what they liked or disliked. They can decide in the end not to change their old routine at all if that's what suits them better. Or, they apply this exploratory spirit to other parts of their lives. There's always a new experience to have and new things to learn. It doesn't have to be earth-shaking or life-changing. Learning can be beneficial without being too disruptive.

Conclusion

Education can mean a lot of things to a lot of people. For Executives, it's a way to advance their goals in life and contribute to society, but it can be so much more if given a chance.

The challenge isn't so much in the hard work of learning. It's more managing expectations and finding a reasonable pace so that learning doesn't become soulless drudgery but a rewarding experience. For Executives, such balance involves blending their sense of duty with expressions of their unique selves – a balance that's entirely achievable.

Professional Development

Designating these types "Executives" wasn't something done casually and, indeed, it fits them well. In business, executives (small "e") organize, delegate, and ensure that groups meet goals successfully. Whether as the heads of major companies, small department managers in tiny businesses, or as directors of entrepreneurial enterprises, Executive types shine when they shape goals and lead others toward their completion.

This doesn't necessarily mean Executives must only do jobs with words like "executive" or "manager" in the title, but they do find themselves most at home steering endeavors toward success. Regardless of their actual job titles, they always possess a drive to meet goals. Often, Executives start in the rank and file of companies, and then work their way into leadership positions. To everyone else, this transition can seem sudden and effortless, but Executives know that it was likely something they strategized to achieve. However fast it happens, they earn it.

Mission Accomplished

If Executives have a catchphrase, it would be a triumphant, "Mission accomplished!" Nothing is more gratifying for them than guiding their crews from concept to reality. They analyze a goal, break it into the tasks needed, and organize their teams to deliver. As Observant types, their targets are realistic and concrete, and they know when they meet them because Executives design their goals with clear metrics in mind.

However, these types won't micromanage beyond a loose strategy. They focus more on the outcome than the means. How their teams arrive at a goal isn't as important to them as reaching it. They cautiously choose trusted people to join them, and because they expect much from their well-chosen teams, others can expect much from Executives.

Focus Over Feelings

Those with the Executive personality type may come across as so focused on tasks that they neglect the feelings or welfare of others. They can appear hard-nosed and uncaring, but in many cases, nothing is further from the truth. The jobs they choose and the styles they adopt aren't always "warm and fuzzy," but from their perspective, professional growth and success is something they believe they share with the people in their lives. Providing material benefits for themselves and the members of their group means a lot to these types.

Under their sometimes stern exteriors dwells a healthy impulse to make their world a better place for the people in it. Executives are natural team builders and work best in this context. In their enthusiasm to meet goals they insist their teams do their best, and sometimes this necessitates taking a strict stance. Their intent is benevolent, and their goal is to coax others to do better.

Jobs and Skill Sets

Let's look at some specific jobs that tend to fit Executives well. This list is by no means comprehensive, as these types can succeed in any career they choose. By the same token, even "suitable" jobs may not be ideal for all Executives. Individuals must determine what careers are the most appropriate for them, including what meets their needs and brings them both professional fulfillment and personal happiness.

Suitable Workplace Roles

There's no definitive list of jobs that fit any type exactly, and exceptions always exist. However, this short list of industries shows where typical Executives might feel at home. It provides an excellent place to start thinking about potential areas of professional interest.

These jobs provide Executives with opportunities to exercise their strategic and analytical skills. Each requires a strong work ethic, and many involve a focus on projects and project management.

- Logistics
- Office Administration
- Asset Management
- Accountancy and Audit
- Law
- Military
- Data Analysis
- Medicine and Hospital/Clinic Administration
- Education (Particularly administrative positions)
- Banking and Finance

Less Suitable Workplace Roles

Just as there's no limit to which careers Executive can enjoy, there's no specific area they cannot. However, certain jobs may present compatibility issues, and it's not always about what industries they choose as much as their roles in them. For example, empathetic hand-holding outreach on the front lines of a substance abuse treatment organization might strain this type's skillset, but they can absolutely shine in a clerical or organizer role in the same workplace. Likewise, their patience might be stretched when dealing with customers in a restaurant, but as a line cook or head chef, they may be a force to be reckoned with.

Executives have a mighty energy and often see things in very clear-cut terms, so environments without clearly defined rules or hierarchies can be frustrating. Anything that requires these types to constantly juggle irrational vagaries, uncontrollable results, or hyperbolic emotion may be unpleasant. Executives thrive in systems, even if they must craft these systems themselves, so an environment that doesn't support structured ways of doing things leaves them little place to invest their energy. They're usually happy to give abundant effort to an employer, but if their enthusiasm is stifled in any way, it may rankle them – all they want is a chance to succeed with vigor. Some work environments Executives may want to be wary of committing to include:

- Jobs with no clear path of promotion or advancement.
- Jobs which reward employees based on arbitrary factors rather than objectively measurable performance.
- Teams without a clear authority figure or arbiter.
- Workplaces with lax discipline (rules that are stated but not observed), especially with weak management.
- Workplaces unwilling to implement improvements
- Jobs without tangible productivity goals – Executives prefer benchmarks for their success.
- Workplaces with an excessively psychosocial or emotional atmosphere – Executives may want to avoid a "high school" environment where personal feelings and "he said, she said" gossip are rampant.

There is no job in which Executives cannot excel if they choose, but choosing wisely according to their personal preferences and strengths can make the process a lot easier – and much more enjoyable.

Workplace Cooperation Between Roles

Understanding how Executives tend to behave is one thing – getting along with myriad colleagues effectively, across a variety of personality types, is another entirely. Now we'll dig deeper to determine how Executives can best find happiness and efficiency with their coworkers.

Executive-Analyst Cooperation

Executives and Analysts share a rational approach to life and find they have much in common in the workplace. Executives are likely to use their analytical leanings to create precise goals along paths that others have already established. Their Analyst coworkers scan for ways to improve systems and methods, and are likely to see their endeavors as challenging puzzles needing to be solved. While Executives may not have the same interest in the broader vision, they eagerly latch onto Analysts' visions if they end up where they want to go.

Balanced Executive-Analyst Cooperation

The Same, But Different

Stepping back and looking at these two types from a wider perspective, Analysts are likely to create the mold into which Executives eventually fit. They like to shake up systems and frameworks to make them better. However, much can be said for stability, and Executives can play a role in taming change that's too haphazard or scattered. They slow things down enough to allow the people involved with the system time to adjust to change. One offers a broader way of thinking. The other domesticates it to fit the real, practical world.

Moderating Influences

As moderating influences, these two types can contribute to each other's work in significant ways. They're both interested in meeting goals effectively, essentially sharing the same vision, which adds value to their work relationships. Cooperation between them is the product of accepting they both offer something of value that leads to the same end – effective outcomes.

Where Analysts offer innovative solutions and visions, Executives are masters at organizing their implementation and bringing them to reality. A sincere collaboration between these two personality types is a crossroads where ideas become achievements and old ways transform into more effective new ways.

Unbalanced Executive-Analyst Cooperation

Experimentation and Caution

Tensions are likely to mount if Analysts change things too casually. Executives prefer proven solutions, and they need time to test new ideas before accepting them. These types see anything too original as introducing chaos into their trusted strategies. Analysts, however, are less likely to focus on the risks associated with experimentation. They may even indulge in experimenting simply for its own sake, providing no measurable contribution to the goals at hand. Consequently, Executives are likely to reject them soundly.

Executives may label Analysts as loose cannons with wild ideas. In turn, Analysts might think of Executives as uptight enemies of innovation. When they frame their relationships as adversarial rather than collaborative, they can stop being useful to each other, and the larger enterprise becomes weaker due to lack of cooperation.

If one type is subordinate to the other in Executive-Analyst work relationships, either type maintaining a stubborn allegiance to a particular focus can be problematic. Automatically taking a position without giving a full hearing to any alternate views can be counterproductive. Very real and negative results may happen when there's a power difference, such as a lack of promotion, a lack of basic respect, low morale, and even job loss.

Overabundance of Rationality

Despite their aforementioned differences, Executive-Analyst work partnerships still pair two very similar types. Both rely on rationality. Effective solutions motivate each type. Both are capable of neglecting the more human aspect of their endeavors in favor of accomplishing determined goals.

Neither of these types is humble in their approach to life. Without a devil's advocate, these types can potentially barrel down the wrong path, tapping into each other's confidence and siphoning off energy and support. Executives stand firmly in their convictions of the right way to do things, while Analysts often flaunt their intelligence. Either form of pride may close off any input from third parties, denying them some valuable information.

Rebalancing Executive-Analyst Cooperation

Breaking a Stalemate

If Executive and Analyst coworkers find themselves in conflict too often, they may need to define for themselves what the other offers. In the heat of battle, it's easy to downplay the value of coworkers who aren't in agreement. Reminding themselves of each other's value may restore balance. But more than a "touchy-feely" approach, these types need to quantify real results or potential results for each to take this assessment seriously. Doing so not only breaks the stalemate, but can also help these coworkers revisit some strategic human resource possibilities they might have forgotten.

Here is one way these types can approach chronically contentious relationships at work:

- Take an inventory of each other type's success (or measurable movement toward success.) This inventory should be real profiles in productivity and not merely a list of qualifications. Reciting qualifications may impress, but they don't necessarily speak to effectiveness and results.
- Once the inventory is complete, review how much of the material on the list is still relevant to future work and goals.
    - What have these Executives (or Analysts) done, or are doing well, and how can this be applied to the job at hand?
    - Where do these coworkers' interests overlap?
    - How can they strategically tap into each other's skills or strengths to be even more effective as a team?

In the busy workaday world, it can be easy to forget things that were once appreciated. Sometimes it takes a moment of paying attention again to rebalance a team.

Bringing In Fresh Perspectives

When Executives and Analysts become too insulated by their similar styles, they need to discover methods to open their shared processes. Actively seeking out a wider range of ideas can help craft a more robust strategy. In-house town hall meetings that are open to all can expand points of view (if they're in a position to organize them), or simply eating lunch with a wide variety of people can accomplish the same.

It's easy to develop stereotypes of people with different approaches and dismiss them based on those stereotypes. When this happens, the best-case scenario is that it's done unconsciously. However, sometimes individuals more actively reject others based on differences. Executives and Analysts who develop an "echo chamber" at work can examine any stereotypes of others and explore their biases. Rounding out their ideas with the varied ideas of others, even if it makes them uncomfortable at times, can contribute to their general effectiveness.

Executive-Diplomat Cooperation

The Pragmatic Doer Meets the Idealistic Dreamer

In classic advertising, there's an old aphorism: "A good ad sells the sizzle, not the steak." This distinction is sometimes apparent when Executives and Diplomats work together. Executives manage the steak, which deals with an essential concrete product or service. Diplomats add the human element and strive to touch the emotions or sensibilities of coworkers, consumers, or clients, thus providing the sizzle. Executives ground Diplomats in the reality of concrete tasks and measurable goals.

Diplomats, on the other hand, help Executives experience the more "human" features of an endeavor. When the pragmatic doer meets the idealistic dreamer, interesting collaborations can occur.

Balanced Executive-Diplomat Cooperation

Complementary Perspectives

Another useful dynamic when Executives and Diplomats work together is also a common feature when Intuitive types team with Observant types. Executives prefer dealing with specific details and concrete realities, while Diplomats pull back and engage the sometimes less tangible big picture. Understanding this difference, each balances the other with equally valuable perspectives.

While Executives are busy with quotas and hard numbers, Diplomats can remind them of things like employee morale and alignment with company missions statements. Both can be vital perspectives needed for creating well-rounded success. Learning to incorporate both into a single endeavor can promise more enduring triumphs.

Unbalanced Executive-Diplomat Cooperation

Realistic versus Idealistic

To Executives, Diplomats' approach of catering to the emotional needs and sensibilities of those impacted may appear to be quirky and "soft." Such lofty idealism may seem outside the scope of their practical goals. Meanwhile, Diplomats may see Executive pragmatism as hard-hearted and lacking in empathetic connection to those in their orbit. Executives, in their opinions, are cold guardians of a rigid system. Either may roll their eyes whenever the other expresses things that give them their strength and employable value.

Clashes can occur when Executives pursue efficient and rational directions, but their plans cross Diplomats' sense of right and wrong. Because they focus on outcomes more than processes, Executives can become baffled when intangibles like fairness and job satisfaction influence Diplomats more than hard metrics. Diplomats can obsess

over processes if they believe they impinge on the rights and welfare of others to any extent.

It all comes down to degrees of emotional intelligence. Diplomats are fluent in the language of emotions and treat them as being greatly significant. As social creatures, Executives are surely familiar with feelings, but aren't as fluent as Diplomats and they don't allow them to have the same impact that Diplomats do. Diplomats feel comfortable making decisions based on affective considerations, while Executives are less inclined to do so.

Attention to Detail

Conflicts can arise between these types over either their respective attention, or lack of attention, to detail. If some coworkers appear 10 minutes early for work, and others are 10 minutes late, it's easy to guess which are Executives and which are Diplomats. It's not that the Diplomats purposely thumb their noses at the system by rebelliously arriving late. It's just that the item "arrive on time for work" may not top their unconscious priority list. However, there's no doubt that punctuality is high on Executives' list of priorities.

These differences aren't limited to arriving on time. There are many ways they show up in a workday, such as protocols, for example. Diplomats are more likely than Executives to ignore the chain of command. If they see an opportunity to advance their humanistic agenda, they can take it right to the top rather than send their idea through their more immediate supervisors – possibly knowing it might be tabled at that level. Jobs are unique in the protocols and details they emphasize, and while you can count on Executives to honor them, Diplomats can treat them more loosely.

Executives rely, in part, on rules, protocols, and exacting behaviors as parameters to use in defining their purpose and direction. As managers, they may be unwilling to cut tardy Diplomats any slack. Diplomats may view Executives' response as "nitpicking," condescending, and lacking substance. If these Diplomats are subordinates, conflict can rise to a substantial level that includes reprimands and perhaps even termination. If the two types are on a peer level, their respective styles of handling details can be endlessly annoying and strain their working relationships.

Rebalancing Executive-Diplomat Cooperation

Searching for Common Ground

People sometimes draw cartoonish, two-dimensional profiles in their minds to represent others they don't fully understand. Multidimensional Executives and Diplomats are more alike than not. Many of their goals are likely similar. While their differences may occasionally impact their ability to work together, they're both values-based individuals, even though their principles take somewhat different forms of expression. In the end, they both come to work to earn a paycheck and fulfill their ambitions.

Executives want to create a stable world where they can live responsibly, take care of those they love and respect, and meet the material needs of all. They may not always verbalize it – instead, they opt to demonstrate it. Diplomats, likewise, seek an idealized version of this, where people realize their potential and have all their needs met. For them, it's physical, spiritual, and emotional, and they may wear their hearts more prominently on their sleeves. Essentially, it's the same desire approached differently.

Toward True Cooperation

Reframing their approaches as different paths to the same results can help Executives and Diplomats restore any lost cooperation. To accomplish this, each must recognize there's no superior path to the results they seek. Each potentially contributes in valuable ways. (The amount of such valuable contribution isn't determined by type alone.)

Working together, the two types can practice active listening, so they comprehend fully what each other is saying and has to offer. There's no room for dogmatism. Declaring, "This is the right way to do it," or "This is the wrong way to do it," without some understanding that there can be options outside of this binary choice is likely to kill collaboration with Diplomats. However, Diplomats offer their own binary choices based on moral right or wrong. Active listening – with the goal of understanding all nuances – helps dispel black-and-white thinking. Broader understanding opens the door to genuine cooperation between these types.

Executive-Sentinel Cooperation

Working with other Sentinels appeals to Executives' pragmatism, a characteristic shared by all types in this Role. With Sentinel peers, they can avoid some of the issues they face with less practical colleagues.

Balanced Executive-Sentinel Cooperation

Sharing a Sense of Mission

Executives and other Sentinels honor efficiency, details, and protocols. These mutually supportive relationships reinforce and respect each other's diligence. As Executives ascend (as they typically do) to leadership roles, they can rely heavily on other Sentinels to help them meet their goals. They can feel confident their Sentinel cousins understand their objectives, and this like-mindedness can foster a sense of cohesion.

Executives and Sentinels, sitting together in the lunchroom, tend to discuss down-to-earth matters. Their conversations flow easily because they share fundamental values. Work is serious business to both types, and among other things, they can discuss how projects are progressing. They can talk about the strengths and weaknesses of their coworkers. (They may base their judgments on coworkers' effectiveness, but they're just as likely to measure them against set company standards.) These discussions revolve around "what is" rather than "what if" – topics about concrete matters that lead to material results steer their conversations.

Sharing a Sense of Style

Whether they're leaders or not, Executives find other Sentinels similarly attached to successful outcomes. They share a belief that the path to superior results is clear and direct. If they're problem-solving, they

might prefer using Occam's razor as a guide – *the most straightforward solution with the fewest assumptions is to be considered first*.

For example, if the number of widgets produced in a day is too low, they may look at the physical machinery and assembly process before they consider more complex things like morale, production algorithms, and other less concrete considerations. They may eventually need to consider intangibles like morale, but if there's a simpler answer, they're likely to discover it quicker than types who are more likely to spend time considering complex solutions first. In other words, their shared pragmatism rules their evidence-gathering and decision-making, often to their advantage.

Executives and Sentinels obviously think in similar ways, narrowing any potential gap between stylistic approaches. Without Executives having to translate their style, as they would with a type which employs a different process, their work with other Sentinels is more streamlined.

Unbalanced Executive-Sentinel Cooperation

Inflexibility Breeds Boredom

Like-minded coworkers can be a pleasure. However, they can also help create an insular environment. Pairing with a similar type can also result in a tedious abundance of the same thing. For Executive-Sentinel collaborations, the tedium plays out mainly through their established expectations and lack of flexibility.

Aegis of Standards

While embracing established methods promotes stability, being unreceptive to new ideas bodes poorly in the modern business world. Few businesses have remained as they were 20 years ago, and they'll be unrecognizable 20 years from now. Too many Sentinels in a room can potentially slow down innovation – and, consequently, productivity – to a snail-like pace.

Executives and Sentinels may support each other in rejecting necessary innovations. They can show an intolerance for others who introduce unorthodox methods too quickly. Executives can approve of even

the most novel concept if they're confident it brings positive results. However, too much combined Sentinel reverence for tradition can render new ideas and methods a threat to their established ways of operating, at least initially.

Leaders who depend on those too similar to themselves may discover such advisors are a cluster of "yes men" who are less likely to offer constructive criticism or useful pushback. The costly luxury of having a room full of like-minded individuals can lead to a lack of needed change. Welcome to the dreaded echo chamber.

The Problem with Occam's Razor

While the simplest solution is often the best, Occam's razor falls short when more complex solutions are needed. Eliminating the simplest solutions first can be time-consuming and ineffective, especially when answers are urgently needed. When there's a tyranny of style, with an Executive-Sentinel majority insisting on their concrete methods, there may not be enough intellectual diversity.

Obviously, this isn't about an ancient problem-solving principle that Sentinels might prefer. It's about the value of different approaches. As mentioned before, there are various tools for different jobs. Too much dependence on a single personality style leads to inefficiency and lower productivity. It goes even beyond the previously discussed "yes men" to the problem of stagnation caused by shutting out other necessary talents.

Rebalancing Executive-Sentinel Cooperation

Opening the Discussion

Support from Sentinels can empower Executives, but so can recognizing such relationships have limits. Helpful alternatives may exist just a step outside of Executive-Sentinel coworkers' comfort zone. Here are some things both types can keep in mind as they take that first step together.

- Rebalancing may be as simple as considering a current set of options may be too narrow and making a deliberate decision to add diverse voices to the conversation. In fact, sometimes the best collaboration occurs between those with opposing ideas.

- Inviting dissenting voices to the table is difficult. People enjoy others agreeing with them. However, if dissent is needed, an invitation isn't usually required – they're probably already there. They may be sitting silently in the background because of a rigid work culture. Sometimes, they're simply ignored.

Creating a more accepting environment or developing an individual attitude of openness can bring these devil's advocates out of the shadows. When Executive- and Sentinel-dominated groups prioritize the search for right answers over the comfort of being agreed with, valuable alternate voices begin to feel welcomed.

Experience New Methods

It may not be enough to open themselves to new ideas – it can take learning new methods of looking at things or adopting new techniques and skills. Executives are fairly facile at accepting the new, but Sentinels as a group like holding on to methods they know, and can influence their Executive cousins.

Executives who spend too much time with fellow Sentinels at work can avail themselves of training opportunities that explore new methods and techniques whenever possible. Discovering the riches to be found in the constant flow of new technologies alone can continuously enrich the skills of Executives and other Sentinels.

Executive-Explorer Cooperation

It's easy to get the impression that Executives and Explorers are complete opposites. Executives are likely to view Explorers as impulsive and irresponsible. Explorers likely see Executives as rigid and unadventurous. These might be unbridgeable gaps between the two types if they didn't

share a deep respect for practicality and mutual attention to concrete matters. They both gather information from the world more directly and are less encumbered by the theoretical, with which they have little patience or interest (although they may claim they do.)

Balanced Executive-Explorer Cooperation

Practical and Tangible

Executives and Explorers most often complement each other when things go wrong. Executives look for results and solutions to problems. They aren't always concerned with the methods – as long as they aren't too unorthodox. When established procedures fail, and they call for improvisation, Explorer coworkers are irreplaceable. They think on their feet and are masters at solving everyday concrete puzzles, providing the results Executives desire.

Independent

Executives are expert delegators who prefer to either develop, or be part of, a team which someone winds up and releases to run like clockwork. This fits Explorers precisely, since they prefer to work without interference and excessive restrictions. They crave independence.

However, Explorers must earn their free rein from Executives – and, luckily, this resourceful personality type has little problem proving themselves to their managers or their teams. If left to their own devices, Explorers typically pour themselves into their work, paying attention to mastering the situation.

Unbalanced Executive-Explorer Cooperation

Tight Ship versus Free-Form Solutions

Executives may appreciate Explorers' clever, spontaneous solutions that save the day on occasion. However, there are limits, and they can reach a point where enough of Explorers' less-than-stringent regard for the rules becomes too much. Rules represent stability to Executives. There's nothing more important to them than their department's or

company's ship remaining upright. Explorers who take too many liberties can begin to represent a serious threat to their overall steadiness.

If Executives are their bosses or managers, they can clamp down excessively on Explorers. Such excessive attempts to pull them into the fold and micromanage them can damage sound working relationships by ignoring the strengths Explorers bring. Tightening the reins may be an ill-advised solution.

Should Explorers be in charge, Executives can feel things are a bit chaotic. They may continuously look to their Explorer leaders to enforce order, and then deal with some disappointment when they don't. Executives can lose respect for Explorer managers they view as being "sloppy" with protocols. They may even feel condescending toward their undisciplined superiors. Similar dynamics occur when there's a lateral relationship between Executives and Explorers.

Losing Autonomy

Executives can provide a strong tempering influence on Explorers' need for independence. But there are rules to follow, and if Executives sense a laxness on the part of Explorers, they may overcompensate by micromanaging.

When Executives challenge Explorers' autonomy, there's the possibility of failure on many levels. Constantly contentious relationships are never good in the workplace, and Explorers who feel trapped always look for ways around obstacles – or develop exit strategies.

Rebalancing Executive-Explorer Cooperation

Courageous Exchanges

Courageous Executives can look for ways to learn from Explorers' attitudes. Professional growth comes from trying things outside of their comfort zone, and Explorers' love of change, new stimulation, and independence can help Executives broaden their perspectives a little if they occasionally go along for the ride with them.

Likewise, Executives can help willing Explorers become more attuned to accepted procedures. Whether they approve of them or not, there are always established expectations in business. Executives can help them get a handle on them should they wish to climb the ladder to higher positions or take their job skills to new levels.

The Explorer Two-Step

Executives who work with Explorers can think of this experience as a kind of dance. Dancing with a partner usually assumes enough flexibility where each dancer anticipates the moves of the other, yet there's some structure maintained in their movements. The delicate dance of knowing when to assert boundaries and rules, and when to let Explorers try unorthodox moves on their own, is essential for Executives who work with them.

When it matters, Executives can enforce protocols. When it's not that important, they can loosen up a bit. Again, this doesn't mean a wholesale disregard for the rules, but Executives can find that, when it comes to Explorers, exercising a little more flexibility and taking a bit more of a risk can pay off at times.

Conclusion

Executives value their careers and professional experiences in profound ways. Organizing and goal-setting that result in solid accomplishments help them find meaning in their lives. While they may enjoy success and savor the perks that go with it, those are just ways of keeping score and highlighting their accomplishments. While they may want to remind others of their shared success, they remind themselves as well. On a deeper level, their primary concern at work is their contribution to their companies, their families, and their communities.

Those who learn to include diverse personality types and styles in their work lives find that they don't just add more talent to their collaborations. Learning their professional strengths and weaknesses, and those of other personality types, can help Executives find a way to navigate work and life more effectively.

Some have said that when individuals come to the end of their lives, they're unlikely to think of all the hours spent at work as a highlight in their personal journeys. This may be true for most, but it might not apply to Executives. For them, their work is likely to be a defining part of what they happily consider as their legacies.

Final Words

Executives play a critical role in the worlds of education and work. Peers and colleagues often admire and appreciate them for their dedication, efficiency, and deliberateness. People with this personality type can be counted on to complete any assignments and tasks that are thrown their way, even when doing so comes at the expense of their personal needs.

Besides being incredibly self-motivated, Executives' decision-making and organizational skills keep others on track too. Whether self-appointed or chosen by someone else, people with this personality tend to slide easily into managerial roles. Classroom study groups and company boards alike benefit from having an Executive (or several) around.

Executives possess personality strengths that serve them well throughout their careers, starting from their early school days and extending to their years spent climbing the corporate ladder. But their success isn't without setbacks. People with this personality type must learn how to rebalance their approach to career development to effectively handle roadblocks along the way.

Our hope is that these pages have affirmed the values and characteristics of Executives in school and the workplace, while also offering tools to help them overcome some common challenges. Executives that balance their drive and hard work with patience, flexibility, and self-care are likely to discover new avenues for long-term fulfillment and success in their careers.

So... What's Next?

You've reached the end of this book, but fear not – we've created many more resources for you. Here are a few that might capture your interest:

- Want more tests and insights to help you excel in your career? Explore our Career Specialized Tests.
- Looking to enhance your relationships? Check out the *Executive Guide to Relationships*.
- Ready to build a strong foundation for your self-development? Our *Executive Guide to Personal Growth* may be just what you need.

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